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The Complex Emergence Model

Understanding the relationality between civilisational structures, the conditioning of human agency and the generation of existential risk

Overview

Every civilisation can be read as a set of interacting structures – its technologies, its political economy, its culture – that condition how the people within it think and act. A lineage of models has tried to map them: Marx's base and superstructure, Marvin Harris's infrastructure, structure and superstructure, Ken Wilber's four quadrants of interior and exterior, individual and collective, and, drawing on all three, Daniel Schmachtenberger's *Emergence Model*, in which 'all factors that condition human behavior fit into these four quadrants', each 'equally fundamental, irreducible to the others'.

This article proposes a successor: the *complex emergence model*, which doubles the number of civilisational structures to eight. At its core are four: infrastructure (the tech stack), interstructure (political economy), superstructure (cultural psychology) and substructure (evolutionary psychology). Two interfaces with 'second nature' – the biostructure and the ecostructure – join civilisation to the bodies it conditions and the biosphere it depends upon. Two more transect them all: the metastructure, the cybernetic, game-theoretic and evolutionary mechanisms at work within a civilisation, and the macrostructure, the developmental process by which it elaborates itself across macrohistorical time.

Two questions follow: how the structures interact, and which of them, if any, has causal primacy. The history of social theory can be read as a history of *structural reductionism* – reducing the complexity of civilisation to a single structure – made of three parts: a determinism (one structure drives history and conditions the rest), a problematisation (it causes the problems in all the others) and a solutionism (changing it will cascade through the whole stack). The metacrisis space has reductionisms of its own: a neoidealism that sees a crisis of consciousness and prescribes inner development, and a neorealism that makes the competitive dynamics of evolutionary game theory – multipolar traps, arms races, 'Moloch' – the variable that determines all the others.

The complex emergence model attempts to hold these ostensibly competing causes together, in a single, systematic account of the generative dynamics of civilisational problems and existential risk – one that transcends and includes the prevailing tendency to grant primacy to culture alone.

Taken together, the structures inventory the conditions of human behaviour, and the 'autonomous man' – as Skinner called the individual who originates their own thoughts and actions – loses his place. Rather than extended outwards from the individual as its locus, agency is *complex*: it emerges from a wider field within which the human is situated.

complex systems theory · civilisational structures · human agency · existential risk

Basis

Before co-founding the Civilization Research Institute in 2021, Daniel Schmachtenberger developed an earlier think-tank concept, *The Emergence Project* (2017), oriented towards 'the emergence of a regenerative, thriving, omni-considerate global civilization'. Its central premise was a 'model for successfully addressing the unprecedented complexity and scale' of civilisational problems: the Emergence Model, a four-quadrant framework derived from Ken Wilber's integral theory, into which 'all factors that condition human behavior fit'. This article takes that model as its basis, revisiting its precursors and elaborating it into a successor: the complex emergence model – as a development in applied metatheory.

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